



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 20

MASSACHUSETTS

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Massachusetts's family courts and child-welfare system.

39

MASSACHUSETTS FAMILIES ON
RECORD · 41 CHILDREN IMPACTED ·
19 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
OF PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
14 OF 14

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MASSACHUSETTS AT A GLANCE.

Across 39 Massachusetts families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 41 37 of 39 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$20,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 19 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 66.7% 38.5% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 39	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.1	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 37 of 39	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 14

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Massachusetts families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF MASSACHUSETTS FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

Expense Category	Responses	Median	Mean	Total Reported
Attorney Fees	23	\$20,000	\$72,752	\$1,673,300
Lost Wages	14	\$27,500	\$273,571	\$3,830,000
Other Court Fees	14	\$1,300	\$1,667	\$23,340
Therapy / Evaluations	15	\$1,000	\$6,385	\$95,775
Reunification Services	15	\$225	\$2,028	\$30,425
GAL Fees	17	\$4,000	\$11,259	\$191,400
Asset Loss ¹	14	\$25,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$79,025	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$25,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME - MONTHS

Median months lost		19	1.6 yrs
Mean months lost		36	3 yrs
Total across all families		606	50.5 yrs

03

WHO IS REPORTING · MASSACHUSETTS

Most families documenting in Massachusetts are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		18	46%
Active case: stuck or delayed		15	38%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		3	8%
Case closed: within last 2 years		1	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		18	46%
Family Court Only		9	23%
Unknown		9	23%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		1	3%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		9	23%
3 – 5 years		6	15%
5 – 10 years		6	15%
Over 10 years		6	15%
1-3 years		3	8%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		12	31%
50/50 Joint		9	23%
Visitation Only		9	23%
Not Applicable		4	10%
Full Custody		2	5%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Plymouth		3	8%
Bristol		2	5%
Middlesex		2	5%
Worcester		2	5%
978		1	3%
Hampshire		1	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		10	26%
High Conflict Divorce		6	15%
Other: (Short answer)		6	15%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		6	15%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		3	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — MASSACHUSETTS

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Destroyed and ripped apart a closely bonded family even causing bad health and lord knows what in future, this country, all of us should be ashamed our children are being trafficked and traumatized

— JODI

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

I don't know who I am anymore. I lost myself and my drive to work and be happy. It's so hard when you're constantly being watched and scrutinized for anything you do RIGHT OR WRONG. No due process, No trial. No therapy for my child. Just his father's lies about me and my family.

— MASSACHUSETTS PARENT · NICOLE

MORE VOICES FROM MASSACHUSETTS

Ruined their one and only childhood. Turned their head on GAL reporting and the kids, myself reporting abuse.

— MICHELLE

Destroyed a hardworking close loving family I have lost Everything suffering ptsd The Children are in danger

— LIZ

They have abused children who had already been traumatized by their parent who abused them and their mother and then they were ripped away from a protective parent without notice based on lies and placed with an abuser. Everyone, including DCF has advocated for them to return to [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my kids life is and mine i never got to raise my kids so me being a parent was extinct

— MICHELLE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Took full custody away from us . CPS did not investigate child molestation allegations properly and lie about things. Parental and grandparent alienation is being exercised, and it wasn't recognized by the court the court was biased and vindictive. Took an extreme amount of time [...]

— BERNADETTE

They stole shared love between a mother and her children who deeply love each other. They have caused so much mental trauma for both mother and children that its to the point of irreversible harm to everyone involved.

— ISIS

taken money from me that prevents me from using for my kids when they're with me and not being able to pay my bills and have stolen all the joy in my life and this affects my kids.

— WALTER

Destroyed and broken my family to cover up medical malpractice of the hospital that almost killed my child.

— KRISTY

While I wish I could say "the system failed us," I have learned that the system was never meant to protect myself or my children.

— COURTNEY

Destroyed us. My children are continuing to decline including my middle school honor role student has faked the last 4 semesters of school. My second oldest has SI. My 6yr old bites his nails down to the skin at the base and pulls out his hair in stress.

— JILL

Allowed and helped a father abuse and destroy our beautiful innocent little boy and hurt him every single day of his life.

— GABRIELLE

This system has literally destroyed both my children and myself. Oldest has mental health issues, depression etc. middle has major health issues and is being neglected and younger one is getting the worst as he's not even his child....dcf apparently falsely did the dna as my child [...]

— JENNIFER

Traumatized us both,my daughter is 3 she self harms,I don't trust anyone and I'm extremely depressed I'm in bed crying constantly,I had to quit my job bcuz they kept [] things say to say with no notice

— KRISTY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system didn't just separate me from my children—it prolonged and reinforced the very patterns of control and emotional harm we were already living through.

— GINA

I fled a domestic situation and moved closer to my family and support system. I'm being penalized for moving and he has been awarded more than he ever had before, and he's now putting on a show of a good father. The GAL said if I moved back closer we could go closer to 50/50. I [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has been the worst 7 years of my life. Courts don't listen to domestic abused victims, blame everything on us. Instead of realizing we are protecting they threaten to put us in jail and fine us.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has ripped me away from my child whom I struggled to have for 10 years and had a rough pregnancy; The child spoke and told drs and others her father hurts her and scared. The system didn't investigate then gave him custody while my child and home was ripped away and I [...]

— FAITH

Complete and utter destruction in just minutes. My daughter is in imminent danger, as a district Judge ruled, but family court continues the terror and agony.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The fraudulent racketeering business that wears the mask of "family" court exposes the underbelly of the serpents that have been running financial systems for centuries. It raped, pillaged, attempted murder, and assassination of any shred of happiness or family I would think [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has dragged us and extorted us in every way possible referred us into pressured therapy usage etc dictated decisions and wasted time that only parents should be making. Extortion to the absolute fullest while using our kids.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

I was falsely accused by my son's father for doing drugs and being unfit. I have always had full custody of my other son I have, the system took 2 brothers away from each other. The system stole my 11 year old from me and my family on all false allegations that I have been [...]

— RACHEL

I struggled with substance abuse. My father stole custody by coercing me to sign temporary custody. My father is using my son as his second chance to be a father as he wasn't in my life as a child. Court takes extremely long to be heard and just as long to make a decision. [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Made me mourn the loss of a living child 3 of the first 4.5 years of my Son's life due to gross misrepresentations across all levels to nearly every Court professional including physically, verbally, mentally, and emotionally abusive Mother and counsel.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

25 Massachusetts parents submitted ranked quotes. 25 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/ma.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Massachusetts report comes from Massachusetts respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Massachusetts — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 39 Massachusetts families reporting here are not the universe of Massachusetts families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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